



FROM THE CARDINAL'S TOOLKIT

The Caregiver's First-Week

*Just enough to get through the first overwhelming week — without dropping
what matters most.*

When you suddenly become someone's caregiver, the to-do list is endless and the fog is real. This is not everything — it is just enough to get through the first week. Do what you can today. Cross off the rest with a clear conscience; it will still be there tomorrow, and you do not have to carry it all at once.

Right away (the first day)

- ☐ Write down the diagnosis, the main doctor's name, and one phone number that reaches a real person.
- ☐ Make a single list of every medication, dose, and time — keep it on the fridge and a photo on your phone.
- ☐ Find the insurance card and note the member ID somewhere safe.
- ☐ Ask the care team: "Who do I call after hours, and what should make me worry?"
- ☐ Tell two people what is happening. You should not be the only one who knows.

Within the first 48 hours

- ☐ Set up one place for appointments — a paper calendar or your phone, whichever you'll actually check.
- ☐ Start a notebook: questions for the doctor, symptoms, and what changed today.
- ☐ Ask whether a home-health visit, social worker, or case manager is available — and request one.
- ☐ Confirm how prescriptions get refilled, and whether the pharmacy can deliver and sync them.
- ☐ Put one trusted person in charge of updating everyone else, so you don't have to.

This first week

- ☐ Identify one task you can hand to someone else — and actually hand it over.
- ☐ Stock a few easy meals and snacks so eating is one less decision.
- ☐ Locate important documents (ID, advance directive, power of attorney), even if you don't act on them yet.
- ☐ Note any equipment or supplies you keep running out of, and ask who can help obtain them.
- ☐ Schedule one short break for yourself this week. Put it on the calendar like an appointment.

Money & paperwork (a little at a time)

- ☐ Keep one folder (or envelope) for every bill, statement, and form related to care.
- ☐ Ask the hospital or clinic about financial counseling — most have it, few mention it.
- ☐ Check eligibility for help with medication, food, and utility costs (a benefits screening can find programs).
- ☐ Find out if family or medical leave applies to your job, and what paperwork it needs.

Caring for the caregiver — that's you

- ☐ Eat something and drink water. You cannot pour from an empty cup, and you know it.
- ☐ Pick one person to be your "I'm not okay" call, and tell them they're the one.
- ☐ Decide what can wait. Most of it can.
- ☐ Look up one respite or support option near you, before you're desperate for it.
- ☐ Save a crisis number now: in the US, call or text 988, any time, day or night.

Questions worth asking the care team

- ☐ What is the goal of this treatment, and what should we realistically expect?
- ☐ What changes mean "call us now" versus "mention it at the next visit"?
- ☐ What help exists that we haven't asked about — home care, equipment, financial aid?
- ☐ If things get harder, who guides us through the next decisions?

Keep these numbers handy

Main doctor / clinic: _____

After-hours line: _____

Pharmacy: _____

Case manager / social worker: _____

My "I'm not okay" person: _____

You will not do this perfectly, and that is not the same as doing it wrong. Showing up is the work.

— The Cardinal's Toolkit

This is one page from The Cardinal's Toolkit. For more tools, scripts, and rituals, visit the newsletter and the full book.